

Major Essay: Response to collateral from a prescribed campaign

Title: The Rhetoric of Unity: Analyzing Bob Hawke's 1983 Campaign

Accurate Word: 1782

AI Declaration

AI was only used for some simple grammar and spelling checks and did not generate any content for my article.

This essay applies some theories such as binary and dispositifs to analyse “The 1983 Hawke v Fraser election campaign”, focusing on the speech of Bob Hawke mostly. It argues that Hawke’s campaign using structuralism and discourse mechanisms, political meanings are constructed, and "national unity" is positioned as the framework for addressing and interpreting national crises.

In 1983, against the background of unstable economic and political conditions, the campaign for the federal election in Australia began. According to Australian Politics.com (2026), Australia was experiencing high inflation, rising unemployment, and ongoing industrial unrest, which contributed to growing public dissatisfaction with the current government at that time. Michelle Grattan and Russell Barton (2023) note that these economic pressures shaped the broader political climate and weakened support for the Liberal–National Coalition led by Malcolm Fraser. A major shift in the campaign occurred when Bob Hawke replaced Bill Hayden as leader of the Australian Labor Party shortly before the election. This significant personnel change had a profound impact on the conduct of the election campaign. As Australian Politics.com (2026) suggests, Hawke’s popularity and public appeal strengthened Labor’s position, while Grattan and Barton (2023) emphasize that his unifying image contrasted clearly with Fraser’s more defensive leadership style. During times of economic hardship, the reporting methods and promotional strategies employed by the media play a significant role in shaping the opinions of voters. These conditions provide the discursive context in which meanings such as “unity” and “division” are constructed and made politically significant. Overall, both sources indicate that the combination of public

dissatisfaction and Hawke's strong personal appeal contributed to Labor's decisive electoral victory (Australian Politics.com, 2026; Grattan and Barton, 2023).

Hawke's strong personal appeal can be seen in his speeches. This essay argues political figures like Bob Hawke emphasize "unity," which essentially serves two purposes: one is redefining the problem by attributing the economic crisis to "national division," and another one is redefining the solution by framing "unity" as a prerequisite for restoring order and development. Thus, "nation unity" is not a tool for solving problems but rather a form of meaning construction. Because unity cannot directly lead to a rapid economic recovery or a significant increase in employment rates. These are practical and objective problems that are unlikely to be solved through unity in the short term. But, Hawke uses a clever method of Semiotics (Saussure, 1916).

From Semiotic perspective, Hawke underlined "unity", not aims to concrete solution, but as a symbolic expression. So he did do step by step: first, it re-defines the problem by constructing the economic crisis as a symptom of "national division," thereby shifting attention from current economic conditions to a symbolic moral failing. Second, it re-frames the solution by positioning "unity" as a necessary precondition for national recovery and progress. In this sense, "unity" functions as a symbol that organizes meaning rather than directly acting upon material reality. This is because unity, as a symbolic construction, cannot directly bring about immediate economic recovery or measurable employment improvement. On the contrary, it plays a role at the ideological level, influencing the audience's understanding of the causes and solutions to the crisis.

Another notable feature, and this is the most important feature in Bob Hawke's speech is construction of binary opposition (Saussure, 1916), particularly between "division" and "unity". Hawke describing Australia as a "divided country", and then proposing "unity" as the only solution, and using numerous specific comparisons and providing many examples to deepen the concept of "division". In the speech context "the politics of division...to poison the very well-springs of the national life...", Hawke describe the previous government through "the politics of division" and "the politics of confrontation," which he argues have damaged the nation. In contrast, he uses the devices of repetition and variation (Biddle and Fulwiler, 1989), he repeatedly positions his own campaign as one that will "bring Australia together" and achieve "national reconciliation". From a structuralist perspective, these meanings do not exist in isolation, but are formed through mutual relationships: unity is considered an ideal state precisely because it is opposed to division. This binary structure is reinforced through repetition and rhetorical patterning. For instance, Hawke's use of the phrase "national reconciliation, national recovery, national reconstruction" creates a rhythmic sequence that links unity with economic progress. The repetition of "national" functions as a signifier that frames all proposed policies within a collective identity, thus, the notion that "restoration can only be achieved through unity and collaboration" was firmly established.

Furthermore, Hawke strengthens this structure by associating division with economic failure. He presents a series of statistics, such as "one in ten Australians out of work" and "one in four young Australians... unable to find work", which are attributed to the previous government and this

links division with crisis. Consequently, unity is no longer merely perceived as a political preference but rather as a necessary solution.

Another notable feature is the concept of *dispositif*. In Foucault's framework (2013), the discursive structure consists of a series of fixed statements and conceptual patterns, as well as power relations that shape knowledge and cognition. It integrates language, policies, institutions, and behavioral norms to reshape Australian society, guiding people on how to think, act, and be governed.

Bob Hawke's campaign speech can be effectively understood through the concept of *dispositif* (Foucault, 2013). In this discourse, various discourses, systems, and practices are integrated into a unified governance mechanism. First, the speech activates this *dispositif* through a crisis narrative, Hawks describes Australia as a country with extremely poor economic and social conditions, characterized by "the highest unemployment rate" and "the highest sustained inflation rate". This viewpoint has been further strengthened through a new discourse framework that compares "divisive politics" with "national reconciliation" and positions cooperation as the only legitimate political response. It is crucial that this concept is achieved through a series of institutional mechanisms, particularly the proposed national economic summit and price and income policies, which integrate the government, businesses, and unions into a tripartite framework. Moreover, Hawke emphasises restraint and realism, "Emphasizing that there is no miracle, recovery requires' common restraint and common burden ', thus encouraging individuals to establish economic discipline awareness. The *dispositif* is designed for the formation of subjects, aiming to cultivate

citizens with a spirit of cooperation, self-restraint ability, and alignment with national rejuvenation goals.

A key difference between Bob Hawke and Malcolm Fraser lies in the presence of institutional innovation within their respective dispositifs. Hawke proposes new governance mechanisms, such as the National Economic Summit and a coordinated prices and incomes policy, transforming discourse into structured cooperation. In contrast, Fraser primarily defends existing policies, particularly the wage pause, as a continuation of current economic management. This reliance on policy continuity reflects a lack of structural reorganisation. As a result, Hawke constructs a fully operational dispositif, whereas Fraser's approach remains largely rhetorical and fails to achieve genuine "apparatus" formation. Malcolm Fraser did mention some measures, such as family subsidies, tax cuts, youth employment programs, infrastructure construction (roads, water resources, etc.), but most of them were merely adjustments or enhancements within the existing framework, rather than a completely new policy.

Hawke constructs a aggressive dispositif that actively reorganises social relations and establishes a new mode of governance: nation unity, whereas Malcolm Fraser deploys a defensive dispositif aimed at preserving existing structures and persistent the current order. Furthermore, in Hawke's speech, many methods were used simultaneously and in combination, but the common goal was the same: to emphasize unity.

Based on Hawke's speech, it was discovered that he employed various methods to emphasize the importance of national unity and repeatedly restated his political positions. In the following part, from a different perspective and continue to analyze by using video as an example.

When it comes to video of this campaign, Aristotle's theory three modes of persuasion—ethos, pathos, and logos can provide an explanation (Aristotle, 2025). From the video “Australian Election-Night 1983 : Bob Hawke Speech” (See in Appendix A). The tone and rhetoric of Hawke’s victory speech after being elected as the Prime Minister of Australia perfectly balanced Aristotle's "three elements of persuasion" ,which together shape audience judgment and enable effective rhetorical persuasion (The Basic Works of Aristotle, 2009, pp. 593–595).In terms of ethos, the most important task for the speaker at the moment of victory is to complete the transition from a "candidate" to a "national leader". Hawke acknowledges responsibility: he mentions the "trust" and "confidence" delivered by the audience, defining power as a responsibility entrusted to him, and enhancing the public's recognition of his personal qualities. In terms of pathos, Hawke has achieved the need to calm people's hearts while inspiring hope. He specifically mentioned Tasmania's voters, acknowledging that they may have different opinions and concerns. Through this' point-to-point 'soothing, he dissolved opposing emotions and established emotional connections. At the same time, he also had a patriotic appeal: 'We have a great country,' which can inspire a sense of pride in the audience and encourage everyone to 'cooperate' for a common goal. This is also in line with Wróbel's (2015) view that a key issue in contemporary politics is that it has become completely "rhetorical", mainly focusing on emotions

(pathos) rather than arguments, aiming to cater to the emotions of the audience. Regarding logos, when asked about the speed of governance, he clearly stated that "not going to move quickly". His logic is that the country is facing deep problems and therefore requires "calmness" and "sensible decisions" rather than reckless actions.

The success of this speech lies in the fact that it healed the rift caused by the election through pathos, established the legitimacy of the new government through ethos, and finally provided a stable policy expectation through logos.

According to Cicero's theory (Fjelstad, 2003), excellent speakers not only need to stimulate emotions, but also need to control emotions, enhancing persuasiveness through "change and moderation". As the winner of this campaign, Hawke's emotions were not consistently intense. On the contrary, his speech was very calm and rational. Sometimes he would also display humor and a relaxed demeanor, and even made jokes at the expense of the audience. Because if the speech remains highly emotional throughout, the audience will become tired, and an excessive amount of emotion will undermine the effectiveness. He did not directly express his emotions but instead let the audience "experience" them themselves. He had a conversation with the journalist and received cheers and applause.

This article explains how Bob Hawke went beyond policy debates in his 1983 campaign, constructing "national unity" as a symbol and governance tool. By using binary opposition and Aristotelian rhetoric, Hawke redefined economic crises and other issues as moral differences,

successfully legitimizing a new consensus based governance model and reshaping Australia's political reality.

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Appendix:



Appendix A: Video: Australian Election-Night 1983 : Bob Hawke Speech (Madabu, 2025).

<https://peertube.wtf/w/87acd76a-b8cd-4a7b-8ef8-4c195bcf4d59>

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